SEPHORA

UX Research Report

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Background

What is Sephora?

Sephora is a beauty product retailer focused on providing a diverse range of “prestige” beauty products to customers. They aim to provide a curated and personalized experience for shoppers.

What do they offer?

Sephora provides a curated selection of beauty products such as cosmetics, skincare products, hair products, and fragrances that are sold in brick and mortar stores in over 35 countries. In store, their staff interact with customers to understand their needs and provide a personalized shopping experience. Sephora also sells their products through e-commerce channels.

What platforms is their service available on?

Sephora sells products through brick and mortar stores, their website, and a mobile application. They also sell through the websites and stores of partnered retailers, such as Kohl’s.



Target Users

74 Million
Active loyalty members worldwide.

Young Women Ages 18-34
Their target shopper usually lives in urban or suburban areas, and is willing to spend on beauty products that they trust.

55%
Of Sephora's stores are located in North America. 27% of stores are located in Europe, 10% in East Asia, and 8% in Southeast Asia, Oceania, the Middle East and South America.



Sources:
https://digitalagencynetwork.com/sephora-marketing-strategies/#sephora-target-audience
https://www.inside-sephora.com/sites/default/files/2025-06/SEPHORA_Global%20Impact%20Report%20-%20accessible.pdf

Competitor Analysis

Main Competitor: Ulta

Ulta is a beauty retailer that carries a wide variety of beauty and personal care products, ranging in price from high to low. The biggest difference between these two retailers is that Sephora has a focus on prestige and higher priced products, and Ulta has a wider range of products that also appeals to lower ends of the market.

Ulta also has an app that users can use to shop, as well as a website. Ulta also has an international presence, although it is not as strong as Sephora's.

Sources:
https://www.ulta.com/company/about-us
https://www.ulta.com/investor/company-information/faq

Challenges

1. Cart Abandonment

Across online shopping platforms, 70% of carts are abandoned. Our goal was to gather information to understand why this occurs, and what if anything could be done to prevent this behavior.

2. AI Beauty Chat

Sephora introduced a new AI powered beauty chat that can provide detailed, personalized recommendations to customers. Our goal was to understand customer sentiment regarding this feature, if and how they use it, how it could be improved, and if wider adoption could be achieved.



Sources:
https://baymard.com/lists/cart-abandonment-rate

UXR Methodology

Desk Research

5 total sources.
Main research question: What are some common causes of cart abandonment?

Competitive Teardown

Compared Sephora and Ulta app, along with their user journeys.
Main research question: What pain points do users experience during app checkout?

Ethnography

1.5 hour observation at Sephora Cherry Creek Mall in Denver, CO.
Main research question: How are people using their phones in the store?

In Depth Interviews

3 users interviewed for 30 minutes each
Main research question: How do people shop for personal care products?

Usability Interviews

6 users interviewed for 30 minutes each using a common moderator guide:
Main research question: What positive and negative experiences do users have with the app?

Data Collection

Desk Research

Full report →

We consulted sources such as Mintel and Statista to gather preliminary information to help direct our research. Consolidated information into 10 key takeaways.

Competitive Teardown

Full report →

Conducted an in depth analysis of Ulta as a competitor, compared and contrasted user journeys for both retailers. This helped us understand the tasks that customers need to accomplish in the app to accomplish their goals, and pain points they may encounter.

Ethnography

Full report →

Observed shoppers in a Sephora store at Cherry Creek Mall in Denver, Colorado, for 1.5 hours. Took notes about their shopping habits and behaviors. Compiled notes into insight about behavior.

In Depth Interviews

As a team, we each interviewed one user each in depth about their beauty and personal care shopping habits. Each interview was unique to the user, with flexibility based on their response.

Usability Interviews

Full report →

As a team, we each interviewed three users using the same set of questions, about their experience using the Sephora app and AI beauty chat. Answers were recorded in a spreadsheet to look for trends.

Study Limitations

Desk Research

Could not find reliable information about user's in store behavior. Also could not find information about user sentiment regarding Sephora's app and AI Beauty Chat.

Competitive Teardown

Amazon was also considered for analysis since it is a huge retailer of beauty products, although beauty retail is not their main focus. Ultimately we chose to exclude this from our analysis.

Ethnography

Difficult to make quantitative observations, such as counting the number of people who check out in a given time frame. Also, it was difficult to observe the same person for an extended amount of time.

In Depth Interviews

Due to time and budget constraints, we were only able to interview six subjects total. Additionally, time was limited during the interviews, limiting the questions we could ask.

Usability Interviews

Due to time and budget constraints, the sample size was small, only three users. Additionally, due to a lack of professional recording equipment, the interviews had to be conducted remotely.

UXR Team

Luke Fitzpatrick



UX Research, Ethnographic observation, interviews, analysis, compiling final report

Andrew Truong



UX Research, Ethnographic observation, interviews, analysis, compiling final report

Vikki Wong



UX Research, Ethnographic observation, interviews, analysis, compiling final report

Executive Summary

Research Questions

What are users' personal care online / in-store shopping habits?

How are Sephora users using their phone shopping in store and what unmet needs can the app solve for?

How does the Sephora app stack up against the competition and how easily can core user journeys be completed?

What pain points do users experience in checkout? Why are they likely to abandon their cart? How can Sephora improve their checkout experience to decrease cart abandonment?

Findings

The majority of beauty consumers use online tools AI, social media, etc. to discover beauty products, but prefer to visit stores to purchase their products.

In store the Sephora app was typically only used to access loyalty rewards at checkout.

Sephora’s account making process significantly increases users’ checkout times.

Users found the account making process tedious and found the UI cluttered.

Recommendations

1. **Implement guest checkout.**

2. **Further refine the AI chat bot to be more credible with citations and less agreeable.**

3. **Leverage the Sephora app to incentivize more in store shopping.**

Impacts

Creates faster transactions allowing more customers to buy their items reducing cart abandonment long term.

*Credible and informed AI chats will **pull in** customers to the Sephora app long term.*

*Funneling customers in store through in app ads will **drive up** foot traffic.*

Recommendations

4. **Declutter the Sephora app UI by reducing menu items on screen and shorten the checkout process.**

5. **Host in person events and sales to encourage social interactions and store foot traffic.**

Impacts

*Enhancing the user experience will **draw in** new customers short and retain customers over time.*

*Exciting and unique experiences will position Sephora as a significant social destination **maximizing** in store sales.*

Detailed Findings

Checkout
Opportunities & Barriers

Customer who abandon their carts do so for a variety of reasons including:

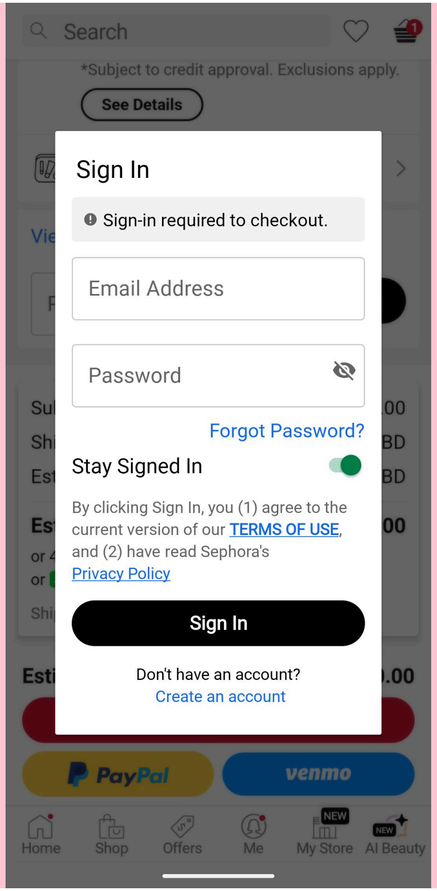
- Intention to shop in store.
- Shipping costs and times.
- Lack of Guest Checkout.
- Only browsing.

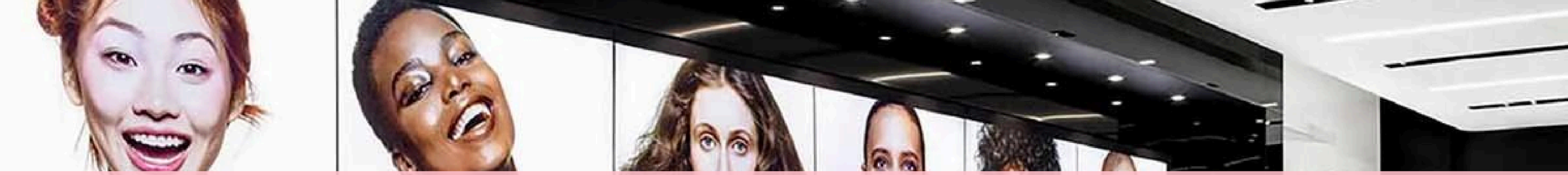


Many users found lack of guest checkout a major painpoint.

“I don't really want to create an account. I just want to buy the thing, you know. So, I wish I could just buy it without [an account].” – P1

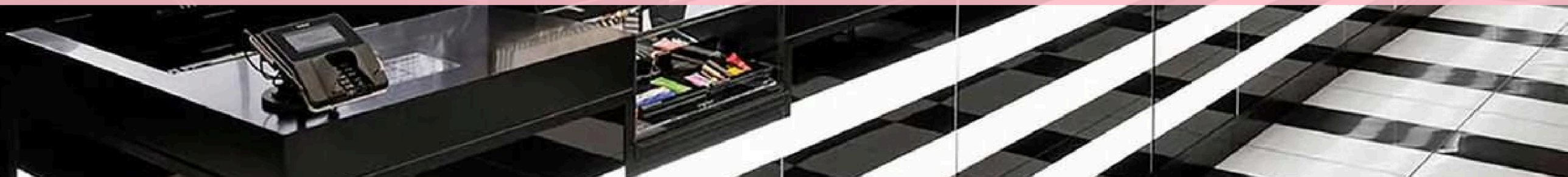
“I'm personally not one of those people that like to have accounts with other companies. Like, do I have to have an account for me just to walk into the store?” – P4

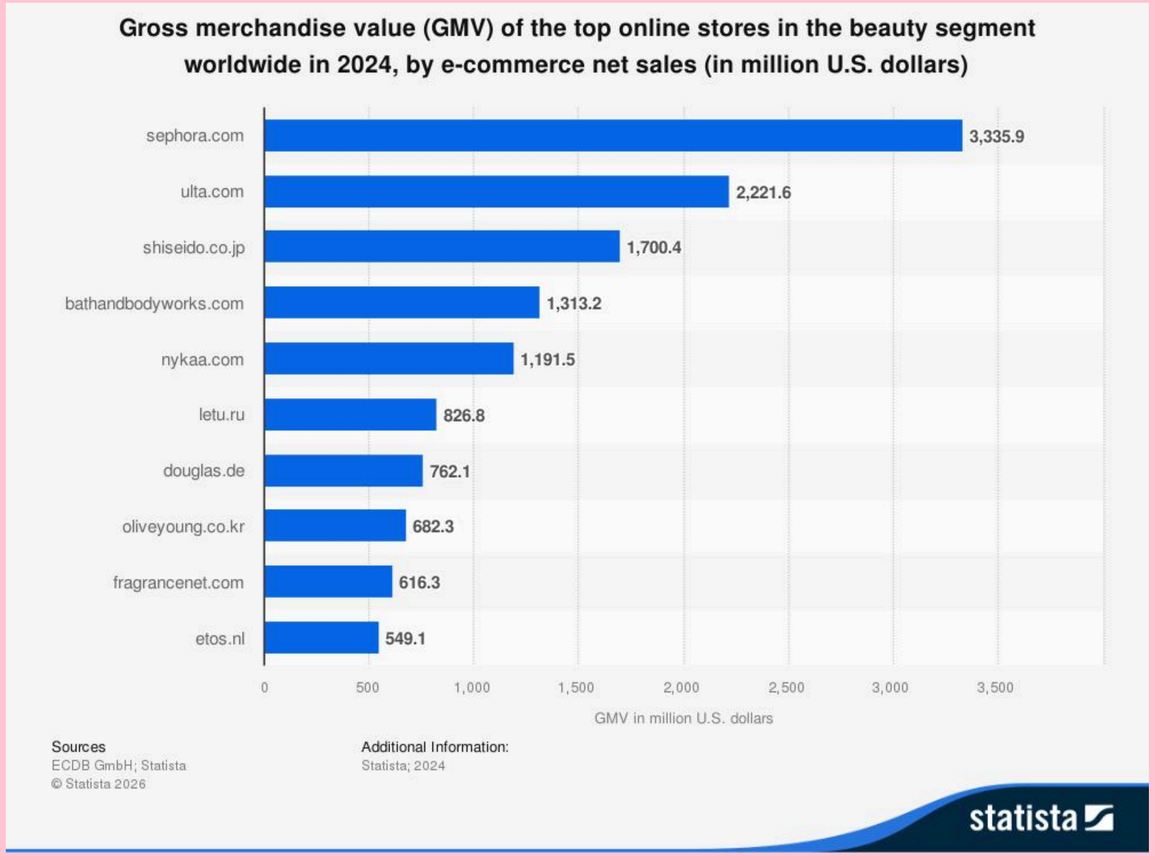




Lack of guest check out was the biggest cause of preventable cart abandonment.

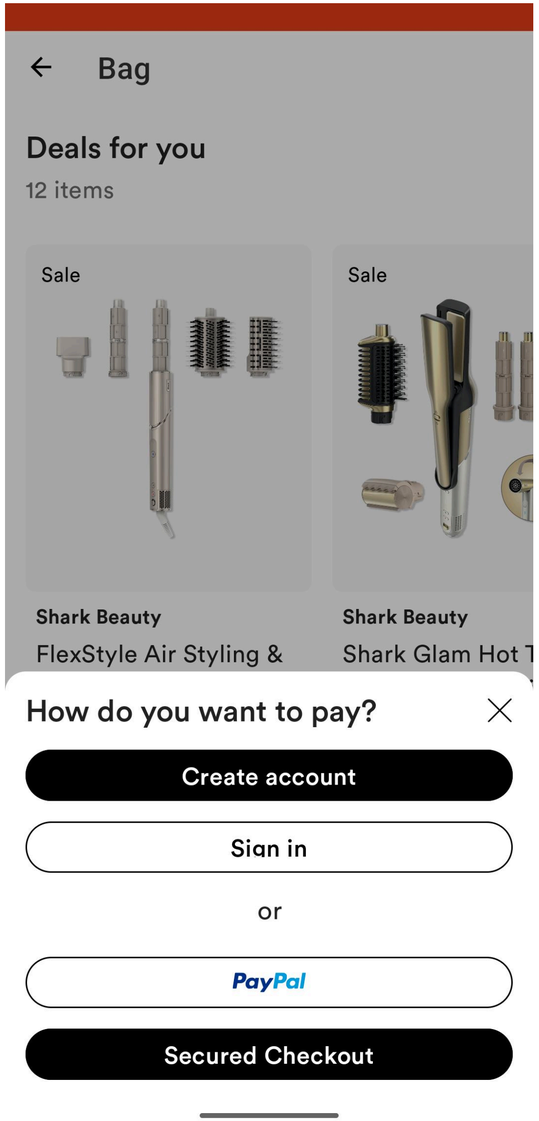
Users don’t want to make an account.



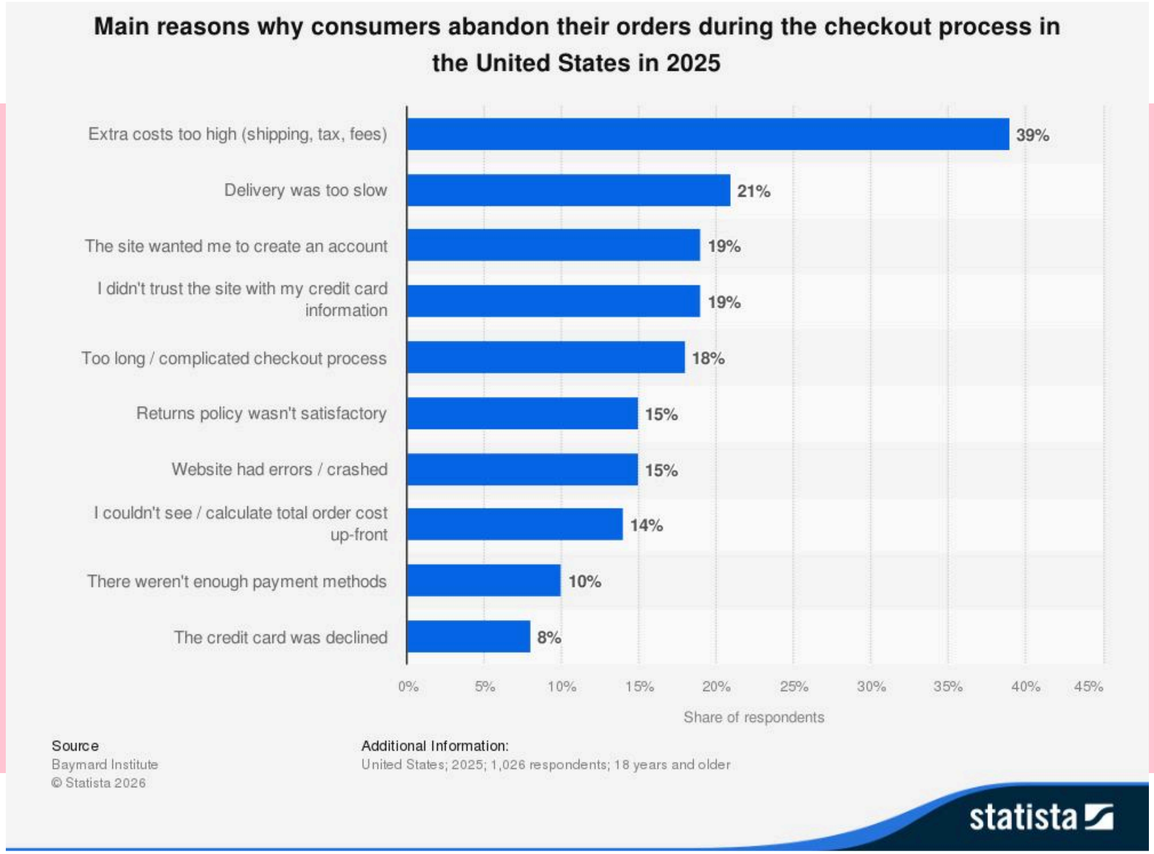


Ulta, the leading competitor of Sephora, offers a guest checkout.

Sources:
https://www.statista.com/statistics/243967/breakdown-of-the-cosmetic-market-worldwide-by-product-category/



Screenshot of checkout on the Ulta app.



"You get the shipping cost, and when it would arrive. And that's usually the problem, because usually I need things a lot sooner than they would arrive, or it's like more expensive. And it, like, you know, just turns out to be more expensive than I need." - P2

Sources: https://www.statista.com/statistics/1228452/reasons-for-abandonments-during-checkout-united-states/?srsltid=AfmBOoqwUPkTO2sjXpshBlwEehmrElz6MmhdMQ5A1CC1DAfdC43L-38i

39% of cart abandonment is due to shipping prices.
Amazon has convenient shipping and is the largest online retailer.

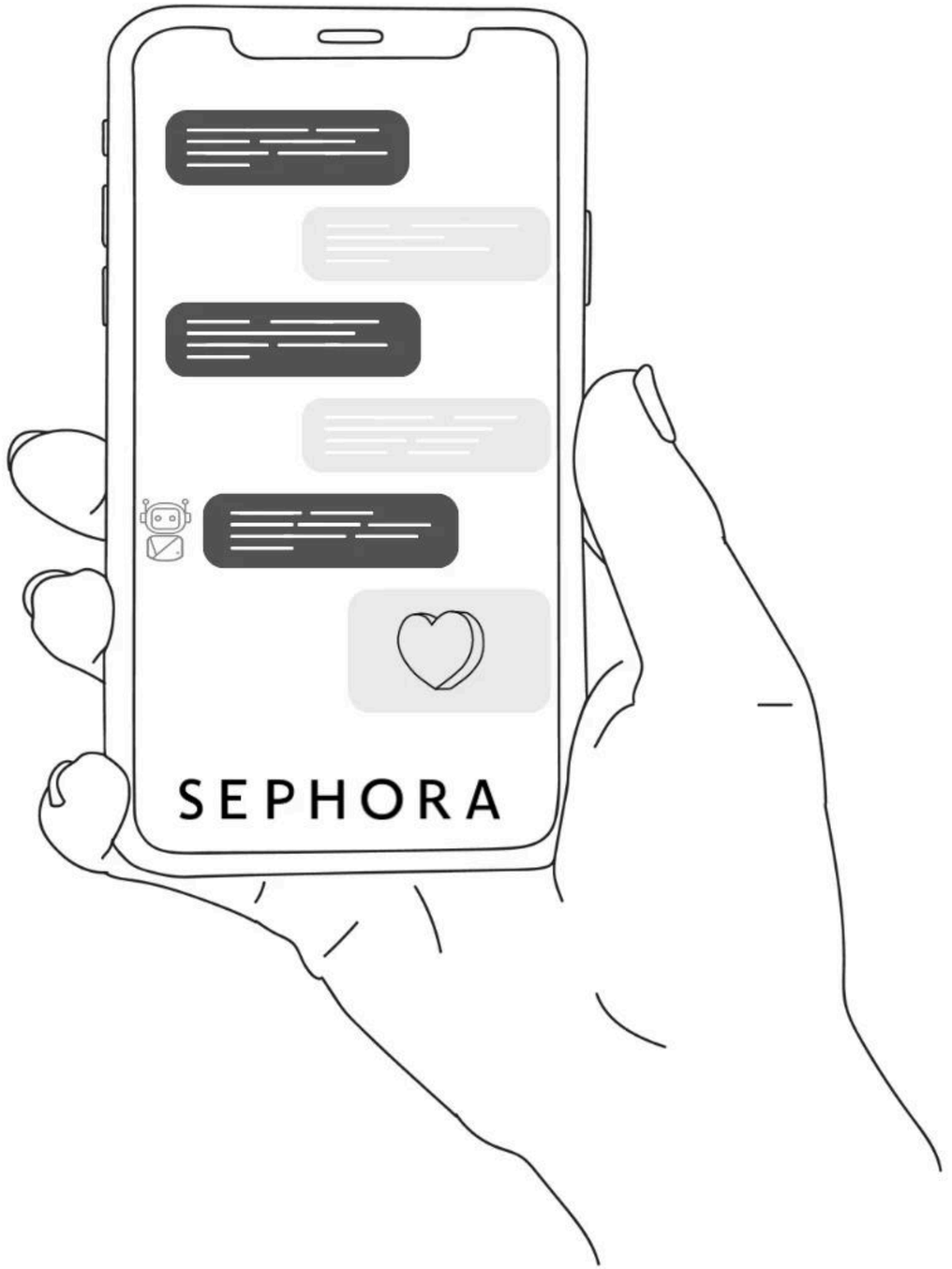


The Sephora app should **implement a guest checkout process**, allowing any user to purchase products.

They should also **consider reducing shipping costs** to encourage customers to finish checking out.

Conversational AI Opportunities & Barriers

The majority of users were not confident or were hesitant to use the AI Beauty Chat due to its overly agreeable nature and the lack of sources for information on its product recommendations.



Most users found the beauty chat helpful, because it provided relevant information to their questions.

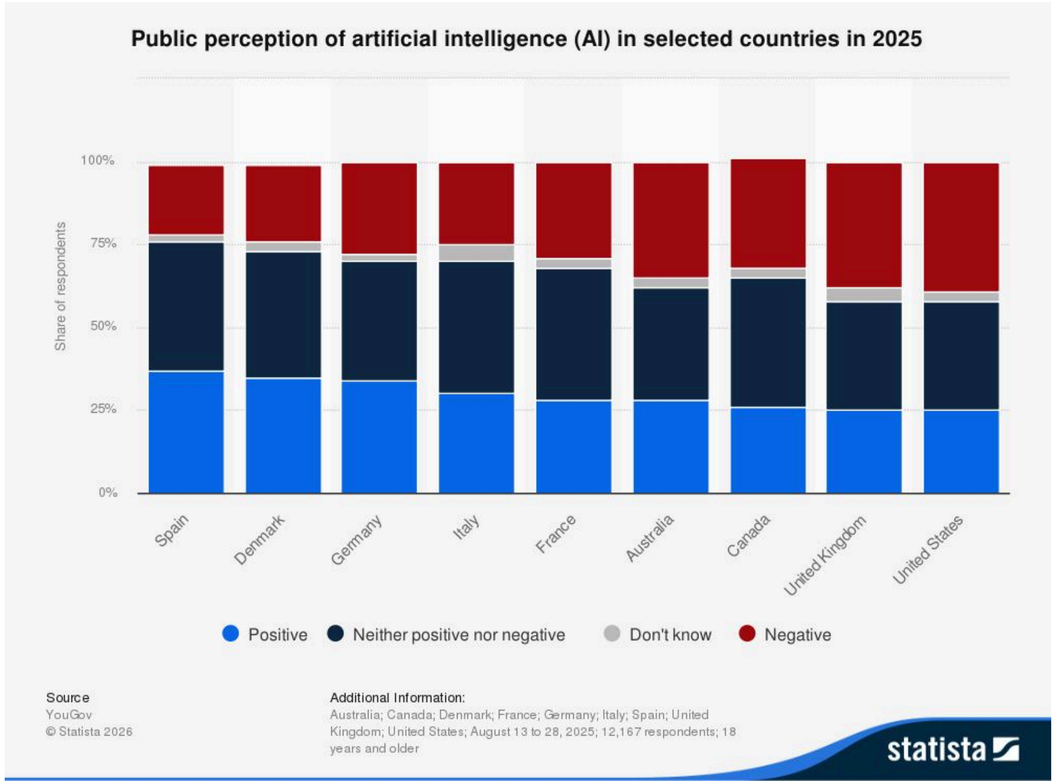
“...Was actually pretty helpful, and it like, definitely dragged me in the right area.“ - P4

“They've paired it with specific products is nice. Um. Is that like? Lowers the friction between, like, mapping between, like, advice from an Ai, and like finding the thing you're actually gonna buy.” - P2

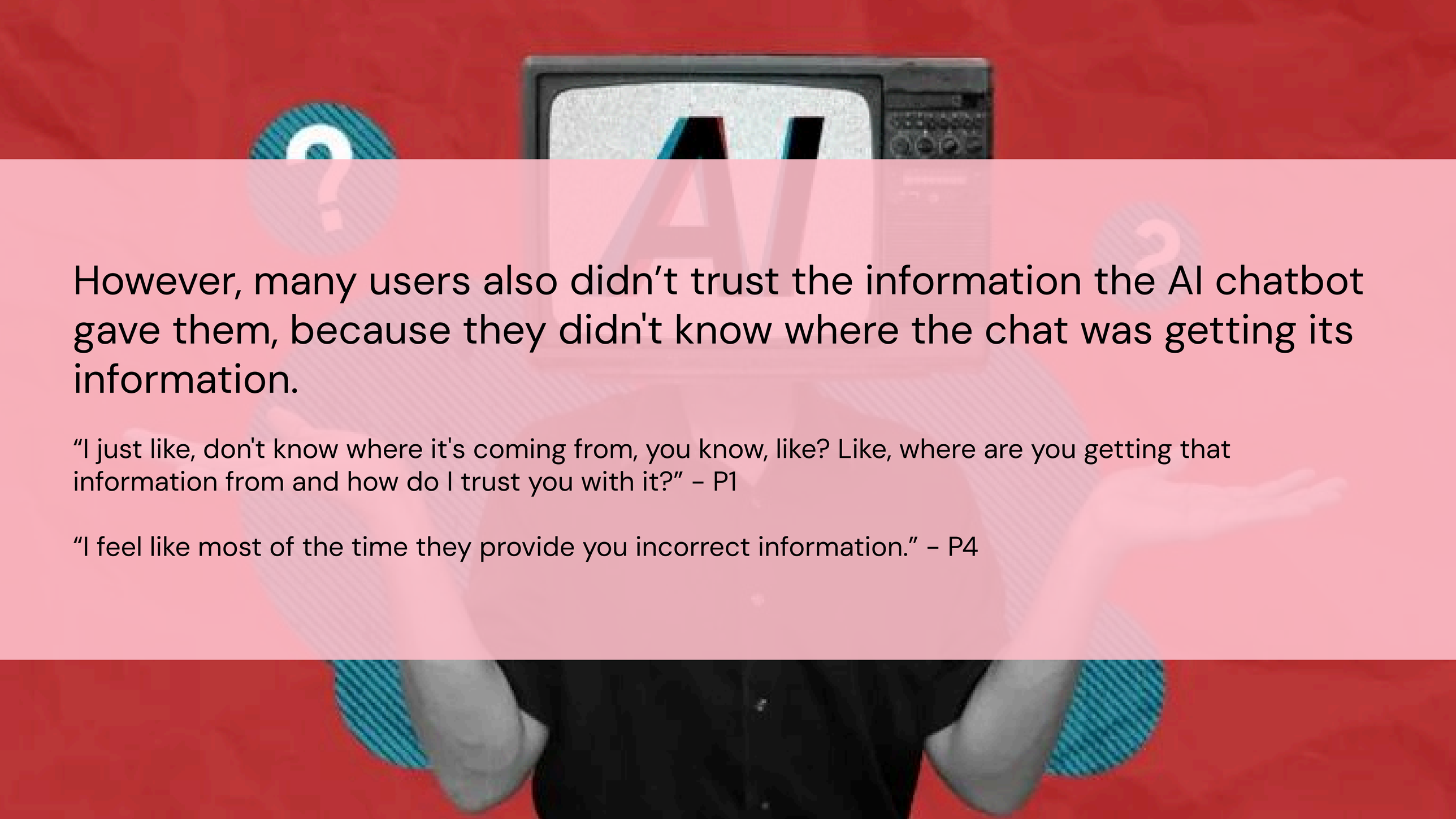


28% of consumers aged 18-34 use AI platforms to look for trustworthy information on beauty products, compared to 17% of overall consumers.

The general public perception on AI is equally positive and negative.



Sources:
https://www.statista.com/statistics/1659332/public-sentiment-towards-ai-by-country/



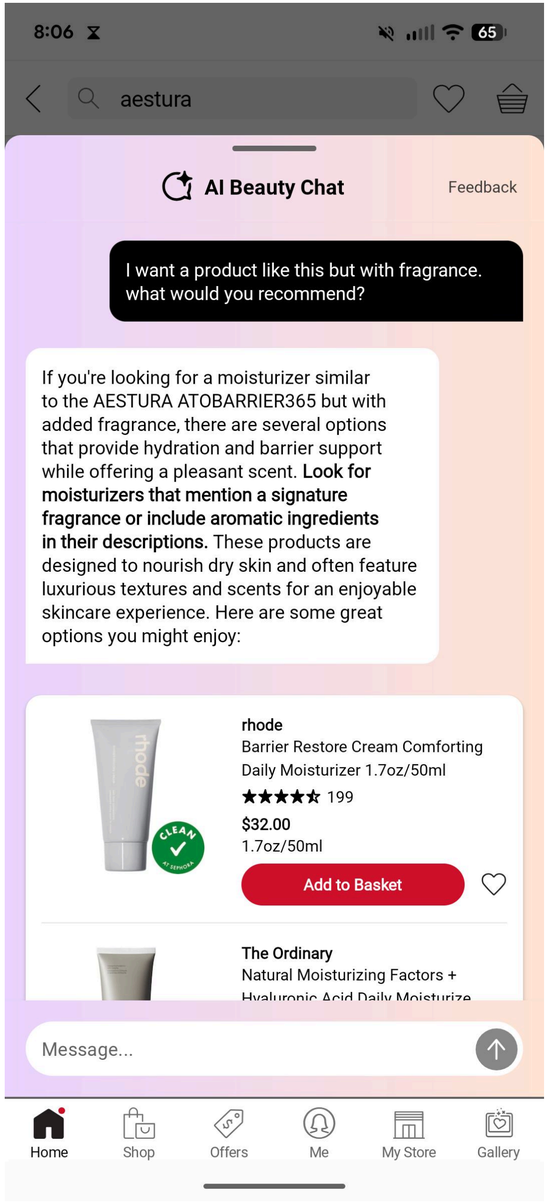
However, many users also didn’t trust the information the AI chatbot gave them, because they didn't know where the chat was getting its information.

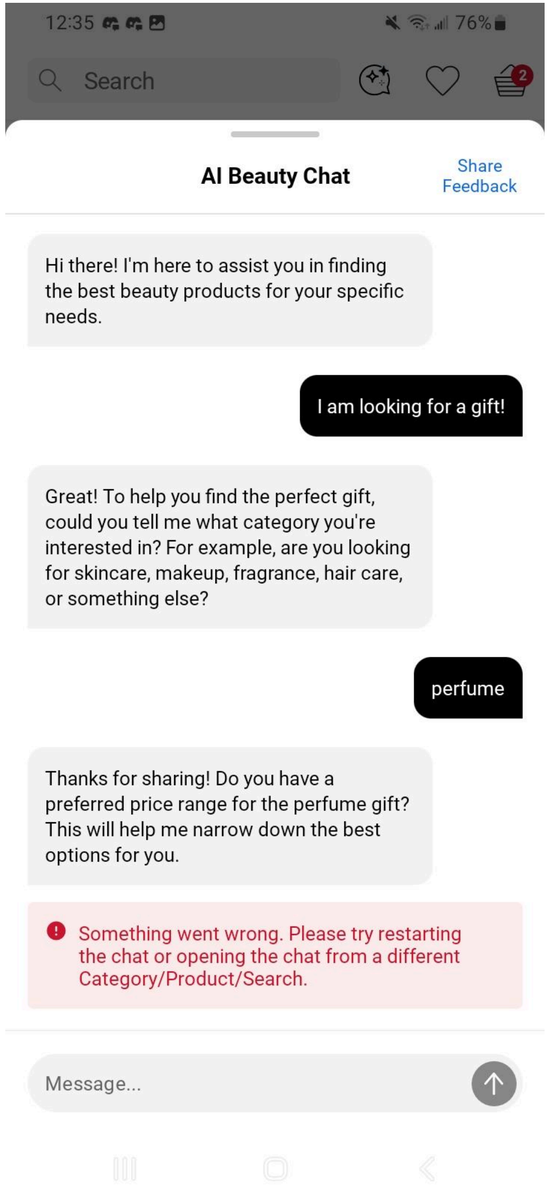
“I just like, don't know where it's coming from, you know, like? Like, where are you getting that information from and how do I trust you with it?” - P1

“I feel like most of the time they provide you incorrect information.” - P4

Sephora's AI beauty chat is easy to use, easy to find, and offers tailored answers to specific questions. However, it did not always work, and had unclear instructions on how to resolve the issue.

A few users encountered friction with the AI chatbot, because it had buggy behaviors that made it less functional.







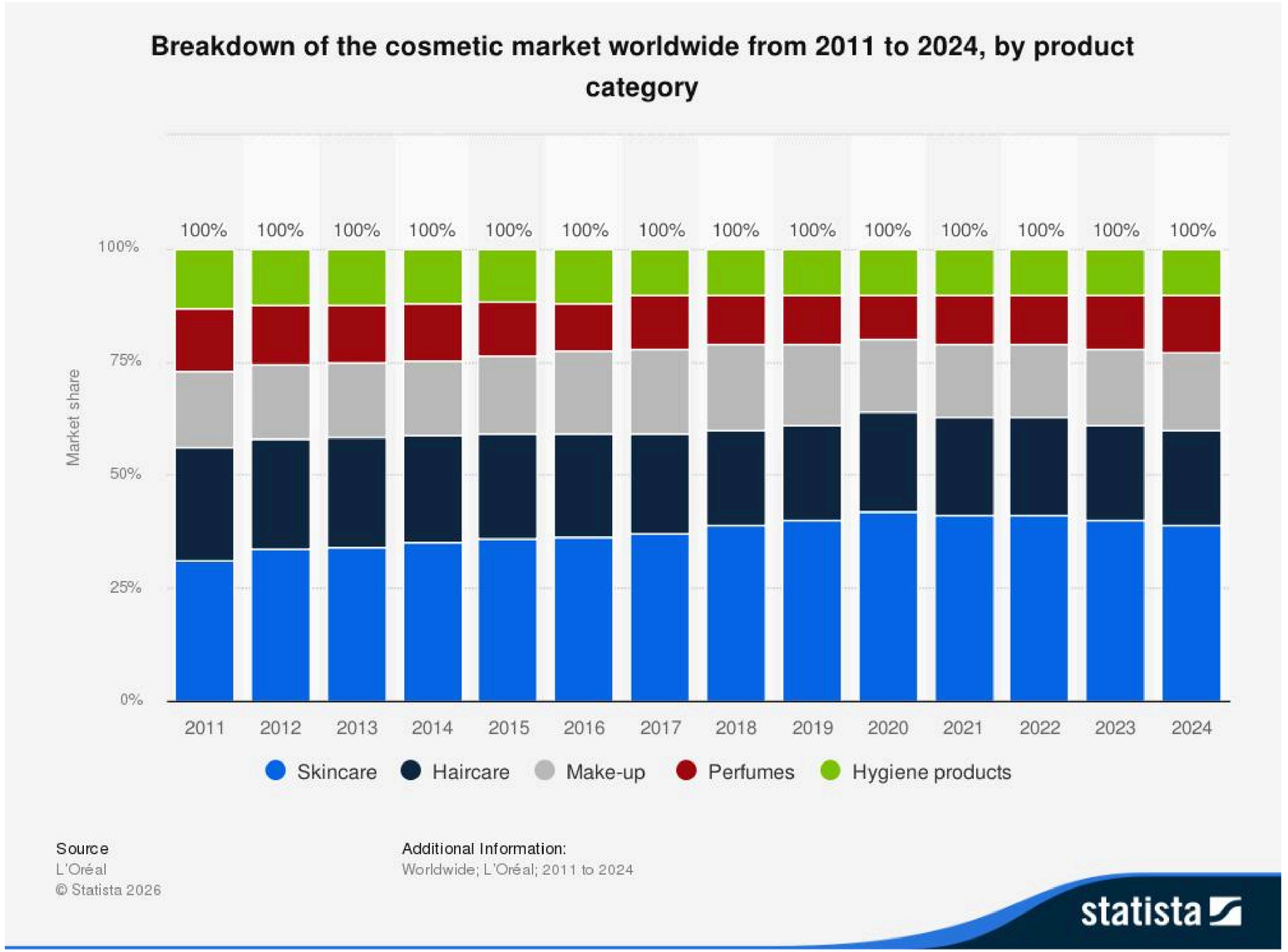
The AI Beauty Chat responses must be **further tuned to feel more credible and perhaps less agreeable**. The chatbot should include citations within its responses.

In-Store Experience & Opportunities

Customers prefer to shop in store to try on products, read ingredients, and shop with friends.

Shopping in store at Sephora is a social experience where users often shop with friends, family, or partners.





"The path to purchase is omnichannel; most consumers prefer to do the earlier steps (research/exploration) online, with the preference for final purchases still in store" – Mintel Group (Market Research Company).

Sources:
https://www.statista.com/statistics/243967/breakdown-of-the-cosmetic-market-worldwide-by-product-category/

Most users stated that they want to try products in store, because it's difficult to accurately assess a product's feel, color, and scent through an app.



"I can take a picture, or I can hold the camera up to my face and shade match. **I do like that on the app, but the thing is, is, I don't think it's accurate.** Because a lot of times it would either be way too light or way too dark." - P3

"What I would like is you can maybe, like, test it and see how it, like, feels. Or how it smells. Like, a little bit on your hand, which I don't think... **I don't know if that's something you can do in an app.**" - P5

"Yeah, obviously, you can like smell the perfumes, and you can, like, try the makeup. **There's really no way to do that on the app.**" - P1

"Yeah, definitely, it's **a lot easier in-store** to scan bar codes and compare things ingredient-wise. I wish it was just a bit easier [online] to see all those ingredients and kind of compare them and contrast them." - P9

Sephora is a brand built on luxury and exclusivity. There is a common consensus among users we interviewed that the products at Sephora are expensive.

Shoppers only bought small amounts of items typically. Only about 50% of customers left the store with a bag.

“Well, lately, I've been on the train of saving money, so I haven't been shopping as Sephora this year, but in 2025, I will say, I have fallen into the once a year sale.” - P3



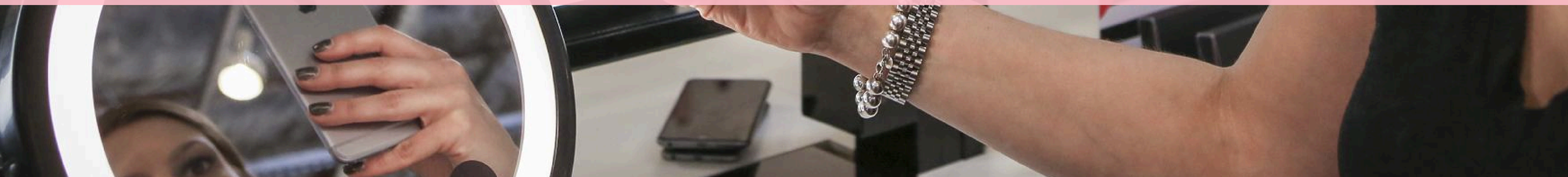
Due to Sephora’s high price point, most Sephora shoppers did not purchase many items. Most customers only picked up one or two items. There were many pre-teen Sephora shoppers, who only purchased cheaper products such as small lipsticks or lip gloss.





There is an opportunity for Sephora to use the app to incentivize users to visit the store in person, and vice versa. For instance, they could introduce deals or discounts for purchasing in store that users can only access through the app.

Due to the tactile nature of beauty supplies, it is ineffective to attempt to replicate that in the app.



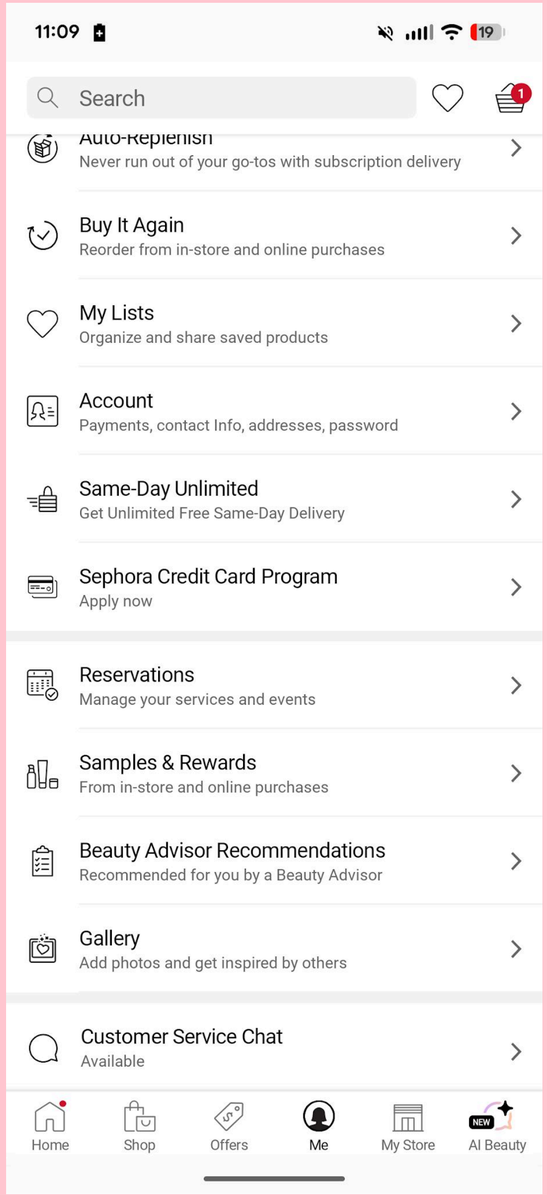
App Value Proposition

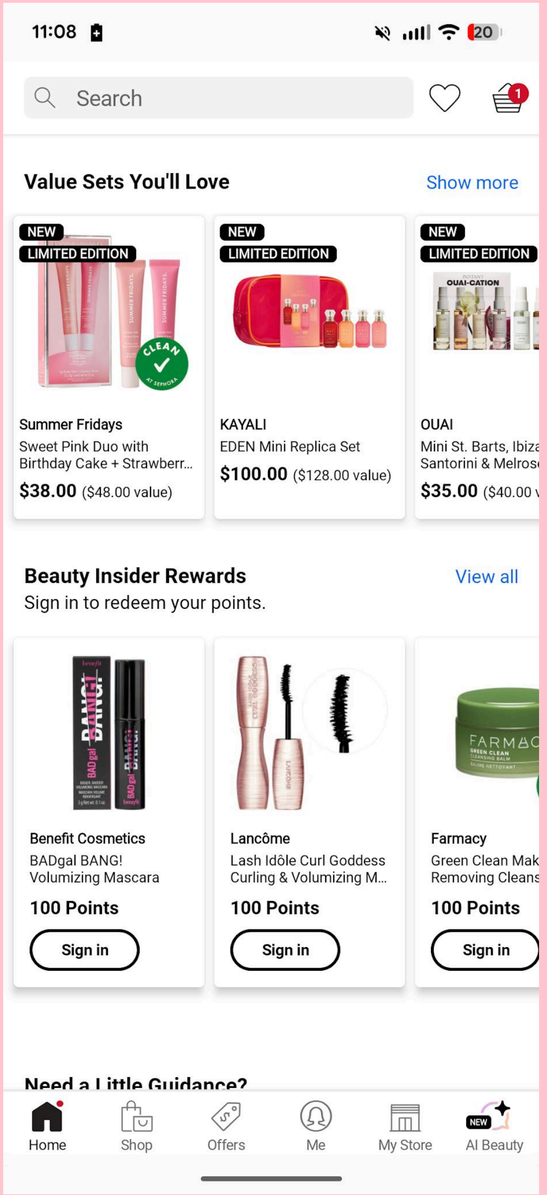
Multiple users reported that the app is cluttered and difficult to navigate. Many users also suggested using a color or colors other than black and white to increase contrast and highlight informational elements.



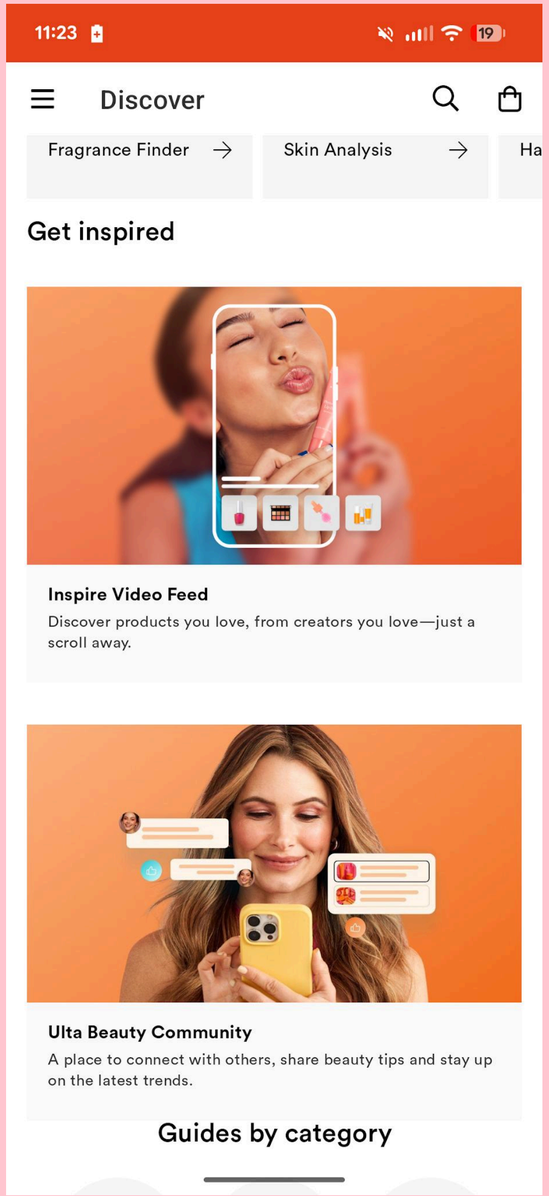
When asked about the user interface , user 2 stated:

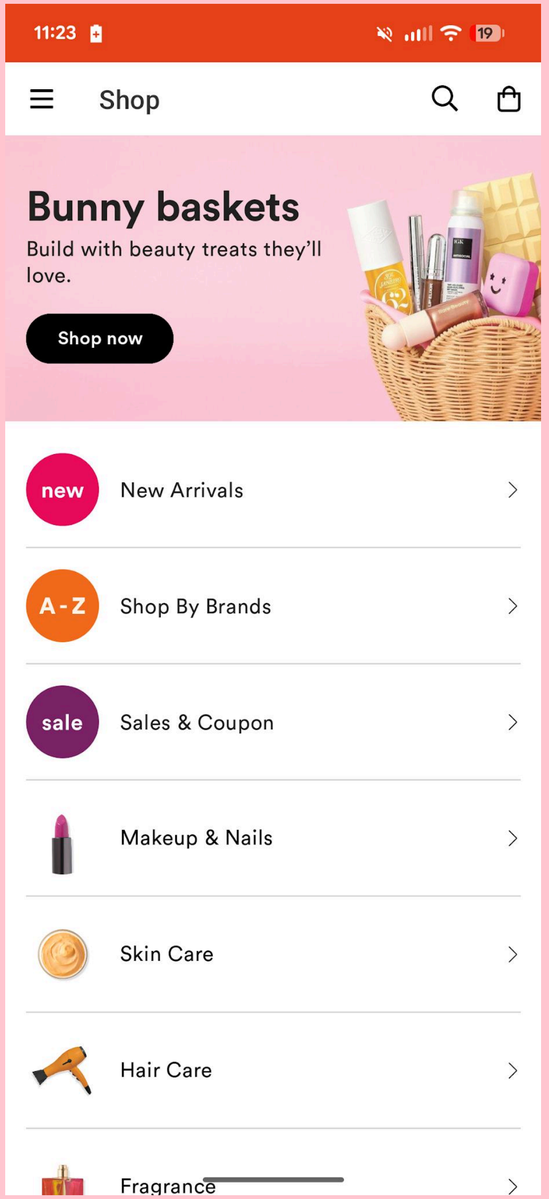
“This looks really crowded to me…I think I’ve made my position clear on the aesthetics of the application.” – P2





Ulta’s app has more color and negative space, making it easier to distinguish elements and find information.





According to a study published in the Social Science Journal, the **absence of bright colors** (ie, grayscale), **decreases screentime significantly**.

Sephora's app would benefit from using more colors other than black and white.



Sources:
https://www.researchgate.net/publication/340421051_True_colors_Grayscale_setting_reduces_screen_time_in_college_students

The user interface of the Sephora app needs to incorporate more negative space to allow elements to be separated. More red should also be used throughout the app alongside black and white, to introduce contrast while maintaining brand colors. This will allow users to navigate the app more easily, as well as increasing engagement and stimulation.



Target/Prospective User

Sephora’s target audience range is 25 -34. The majority of this audience discovers new beauty trends through Social Media.

However most of these customers still prefer in store shopping with others discussing and recommending products as they shop.





Sources:
https://clients-mintel-com.colorado.idm.oclc.org/report/path-to-purchase-spotlight-on-beauty-us-2025?fromSearch=%3Ffreetext%3DBeauty%2520apps%26resultPosition%3D5#workspace_SpacesStore_5bb56041-a429-4b3e-b560-41a4292b3e18

TikTok shop is becoming a bigger presence in the beauty space creating opportunities for Sephora to sell through or integrate with TikTok Shop.

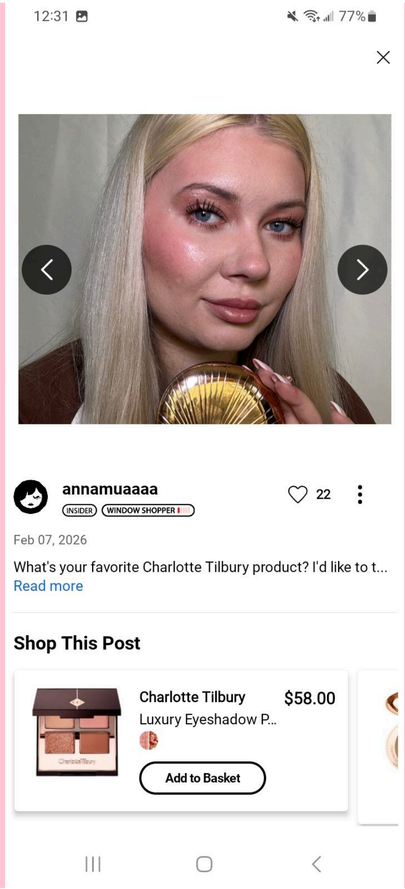
“67% of females aged 18 -34 learn about new beauty and person care products compared to 58% of overall customers.” - “Path to Purchase - Spotlight on US Beauty Mintel

Sources:
https://clients-mintel-com.colorado.idm.oclc.org/report/path-to-purchase-spotlight-on-beauty-us-2025?fromSearch=%3Ffreetext%3DBeauty%2520apps%26resultPosition%3D5



Target/Prospective User

Sephora’s target audience embraces social media event sharing their own photos for product reviews. Sephora can embrace the influence of social media to draw in more customers.



For the typical Sephora shopper, shopping in store was a social activity of chatter, window shopping, and trying on product. Most shoppers did not come in with a specific product in mind, they would browse and pick up what interested them.





Despite the ability to shop online or on the app, interviewed users preferred to shop in store to test makeup.

“I’m like, quite particular about the specific shade of color that I'm using, so the ability to like, put it on my skin as a sample is pretty critical. In fact, I think I would not buy a new thing on the app unless it was like a setting spray or something I knew I already liked.” - P3

“The app seems fine and normal and good. I still don't think I would ever use it for shopping, because I like the in-store shopping experience for things like makeup.” - P2





Sephora should **maximize their social media presence** by running promotional campaigns and adds to draw customers in store.

Sephora should then heighten the instore experience with **event drops and in store promotions.**

Thank you!

Appendix

Usability Interviews Recruits

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6
Madeleine	Hana	Linh	Max	Riley	Henry
Female	Female	Female	Male	Male	Male
25-30	25-30	30-35	25-30	20-25	20-25

In-depth Interviews Recruits

P7	P8	P9
Shreya	Naimisha	Noah
Female	Female	Male


SEPHORA